Butcher (Poems from)

By Natasha T. Miller

The Playground is Empty (pg 34)

When my city turned dark & into a playground full
of ghosts, we stayed, climbed the polls, turned
the lights back on ourselves, & made so much noise
that the rest of the world had to
come back to see what was happening.

Two days after my brother died,
I peeled myself out of bed to go teach poems
to tenth graders, & a week later a girl
who had just lost her mother left a note on my desk
that only read: "thank you, thank you."

It was in that moment I understood,
success is not about money or a bottom line;
success is sometimes just the lifeline
between your journey and how your story
can inspire or save someone else.

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INTRODUCTION

Poems from Butcher by Natasha T. Miller in tribute to the death of her brother.

Family Reunion (pg 8-9)

The day after the dead
dies it's a family reunion
the day after the dead is buried
it's a death

And you have to go to work tomorrow because
bereavement days last the same amount of time whether
you just buried your dog or
your only brother or
lost them both
and buried them right next to each other

And you have to iron your clothes now
when they can no longer see your wounds
they expect you to no longer look like s***
the obituary is already wrinkled
you start to feel like you should be
straightened out by now

It's not like he just died yesterday
it's not like people are still calling to see if you're okay

You should be able to rest now
you're not dreaming bout him anymore
because even the dead can feel when they're old news
when their sons have stopped asking
when they're coming back home
when the rest in peace shirts are too faded to remember
who you were remembering

Who were you remembering?

How long has it been since their profile
became just another picture at the bottom of a police file
since their dirty clothes at the bottom of your hamper
stopped smelling like all the trouble you tried
to pray them away from

How long has it been since your friends stopped
by the house with flowers for your mother
listened to you repeat the same stories
laughed and engaged as if it was the first time they've
heard that name in years

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How long has it been?

How many days does it take for a death to stop feeling
like a family reunion
for you to feel alone

Like an only child
like you've lost something you love and
you can feel it now?

TRANSITION

Grief and an overwhelming sadness: These are undeniable emotions when faced with mortality. But Natasha T. Miller is dealing with more than just the loss of her brother. She continues to deal with the circumstances surrounding his death. See he didn't die in an accident, or from some unresolved medical condition. He died because of the lifestyle he chose. His name was Marcus, but they say . . .

They Say (pg 47)

They say you shouldn't mourn the loss of a drug dealer.
Say the drug dealers stood on the tracks their whole lives.
Challenging the train. Knew that even if the weather
delayed it death was still. Showing up at their front door.
They say the drug dealer died so casually. Say what's-his-

name's-child on Joy Road or Rosa Parks Blvd, was murdered in cold blood. On his front porch. They say his. Don't say his name. Don't care about the death of a dealer. They don't give the drug dealer a backstory or a reason why. He's just another one. They say his. Don't say his name. Say his funeral is next week. Don't talk about who he was. They say his casket was nice. Say his mother was nice. Was burying her only son and still. Had enough strength to stand outside the church and laugh. Don't say his name. Treat it like a weight their fragile tongues are too weak to hold. Don't wanna make the mistake of humanizing the drug dealer. Can't let anyone know they gave a damn. They say his death. I say his death. I say his in every conversation since he left. It's been 1,956 days since my brother was murdered. I haven't said his name once. I say my brother in every conversation since his death. I say his death. I say his. I say his death. I say his. See I'm afraid the more times I say his name. The quicker I'll empty myself of his memory. I'm scared of remembering what his name tastes like. Afraid it'll fall like ashes in my mouth. Buried underneath my tongue. My lips into a headstone. That

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forces me to talk about him. To stop saying his. To say his name. To say Marcus. To say Marcus. To say my brother. His name was. Marcus.

Your Son's Smile (pg 39)

You tryna make me believe you some type of Jesus
    Like you weren't just another Black man
With no father
    Bad Habits
An untimely death
    And a sister that won't forget about you
    Your mama's addiction
Your father's regret
    You deserved this life as much as anyone else
You didn't start this war on drugs
    You were a casualty in it.

I Learned of Grief Too Late (pg 55-56)

Grief is more contagious than joy

It seems easier to hand our baggage
to people we love than move
through the world freely

It's the reason I left my mother
at home to mourn the death of her only
son alone while I went on the road
to perform poems for strangers

Because hurt people hurt people
is so damn cliché but true

So you blame anything on the dead

You become the excuse and the excused,
The burning building and the fire,
expecting to be rescued while left alone

Until you're left alone
and can no longer blame your behavior
on your pain

Until you hear someone you love say they can't forgive you
and feel success and emptiness in the same body

Until you're humbled
until you realize that you're not the only one

We are all hurting and as a result,
all hurting each other.

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Until you learn to be grieving and gracious

Until you learn that this s*** is never just
about you.

To Existing Being Enough (pg 22)

On days like today, you're just existing,
and that's fine.

The ocean is not always a tsunami.
The wind is not always a tornado.

You are no less powerful
in all your stillness.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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